

GB

English Idioms

30 Everyday Idiomatic Expressions · Meanings & Examples

Thirty of the most useful English idioms, each with a plain-English meaning and two example sentences — the natural, figurative language that makes you sound fluent.

Everyday & feelings

Money & effort

Problems & luck

People & secrets

Advanced English study pack

How to use these idioms

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning cannot be worked out from the individual words. *It's a piece of cake* has nothing to do with cake — it simply means *very easy*. Idioms are everywhere in natural, spoken English, and using a few well is one of the fastest ways to sound like a native speaker.

Meaning first, then the words

Each entry gives the idiom, a short literal-sounding gloss (in grey), a clear definition, and **two examples** that show it in a real sentence. Learn the whole phrase as one unit — the words rarely change, so don't try to swap them (*it's a piece of cake*, never *a slice of cake*).

Watch your register

Most of these are neutral to informal and are perfect for conversation, emails to friends, and speaking exams. In very formal writing, prefer a plain paraphrase — but recognising idioms when you *read* and *hear* them always matters.

Study tip: pick five idioms, cover the definitions, and try to guess each meaning from the examples. Then write two fresh sentences of your own about your day. You remember an idiom far better once you've used it about yourself.

Group 1 · Everyday life & feelings — 7 idioms

Group 2 · Money, effort & getting things done — 8 idioms

Group 3 · Problems, luck & tricky situations — 8 idioms

Group 4 · People, secrets & decisions — 7 idioms

GROUP 1

Everyday life & feelings

(To feel) under the weather — *feeling ill*

To feel slightly ill or unwell.

- " I'm feeling a bit under the weather, so I'll stay in tonight.
- " She's been under the weather all week with a bad cold.

Once in a blue moon — *very rarely*

Something that happens very rarely, almost never.

- " We only eat out once in a blue moon.
- " He calls his cousin once in a blue moon, maybe twice a year.

A piece of cake — *very easy*

Something that is very easy to do.

- " The exam was a piece of cake — I finished early.
- " Don't worry about the recipe; it's a piece of cake.

Break a leg — *good luck!*

A way of wishing someone good luck, especially before a performance.

- " You've got your audition today — break a leg!
- " Break a leg out there; you'll be brilliant.

Speak of the devil — *here they are!*

Said when the person you were just talking about suddenly appears.

- " Speak of the devil — we were just talking about you!
- " And speak of the devil, here's Tom now.

When pigs fly — *never*

Used to say that something will never happen.

- " He'll tidy his room when pigs fly.
- " "Will they lower the prices?" "When pigs fly."

Pull someone's leg — *to tease*

To joke with someone by telling them something untrue for fun.

- " Relax — I'm only pulling your leg.
- " Are you serious, or are you pulling my leg?

GROUP 2

Money, effort & getting things done

Cost an arm and a leg — *very expensive*

To be extremely expensive.

- " These trainers cost an arm and a leg.
- " We'd love to travel more, but flights cost an arm and a leg.

Cut corners — *do it cheaply/badly*

To do something badly or cheaply to save time or money.

- " They cut corners on safety and it showed.
- " Don't cut corners — do the job properly the first time.

Go the extra mile — *make extra effort*

To make more effort than is expected of you.

- " Our staff always go the extra mile for customers.
- " She went the extra mile to make the guests feel at home.

No pain, no gain — *effort brings reward*

You have to work hard and suffer a little to achieve something worthwhile.

- " My legs ache after training, but no pain, no gain.
- " Learning a language is slow work — no pain, no gain.

Bite the bullet — *just do it*

To force yourself to do something difficult or unpleasant that you have been avoiding.

- " I finally bit the bullet and booked the dentist.
- " We'll have to bite the bullet and tell them the truth.

Call it a day — *stop for now*

To decide to stop working on something, at least for now.

- " It's late — let's call it a day.
- " After thirty years in teaching, she decided to call it a day.

The best of both worlds — *two benefits at once*

A situation in which you enjoy the advantages of two different things at the same time.

- " Working from home two days a week gives me the best of both worlds.
- " Living near the coast but close to the city is the best of both worlds.

Bring home the bacon — *earn the money*

To earn money to support your family; to succeed at something.

- " Someone has to bring home the bacon.
- " The team really brought home the bacon this season.

GROUP 3

Problems, luck & tricky situations

A blessing in disguise — *good in the end*

Something that seems bad at first but turns out to be good.

- " Missing that train was a blessing in disguise — I met an old friend.
- " Losing the job was a blessing in disguise; she started her own business.

Kill two birds with one stone — *two jobs at once*

To solve two problems with a single action.

- " I'll drop off the parcel on my way to work and kill two birds with one stone.
- " Studying abroad let her learn French and see Europe — two birds, one stone.

Hit the nail on the head — *exactly right*

To describe or identify something exactly right.

- " You've hit the nail on the head — that's the real problem.
- " Her comment hit the nail on the head.

Add insult to injury — *make it worse*

To make a bad situation even worse for someone.

- " The train was late and, to add insult to injury, they raised the fares.
- " He forgot my birthday and, adding insult to injury, asked to borrow money.

The last straw — *the final blow*

The final small problem that makes a situation unbearable.

- " When he turned up late again, that was the last straw.
- " The broken promise was the last straw for their friendship.

The elephant in the room — *obvious but ignored*

An obvious problem that everyone can see but nobody wants to talk about.

- " Nobody mentioned the budget — the elephant in the room.
- " Let's address the elephant in the room and talk about the layoffs.

Get out of hand — *out of control*

To become impossible to control.

- " The party got completely out of hand.
- " We need to act before costs get out of hand.

Don't judge a book by its cover — *look deeper*

Don't judge someone or something only by its appearance.

- " The café looks shabby, but the food is superb — don't judge a book by its cover.
- " He seems stern, but he's very kind; you can't judge a book by its cover.

GROUP 4

People, secrets & decisions

See eye to eye — *fully agree*

To agree completely with someone.

- " My sister and I don't always see eye to eye.
- " The two leaders finally saw eye to eye on the plan.

Let the cat out of the bag — *reveal a secret*

To reveal a secret, usually by accident.

- " It was meant to be a surprise, but he let the cat out of the bag.
- " Don't let the cat out of the bag about the party.

Give someone the cold shoulder — *ignore them*

To deliberately ignore someone or treat them in an unfriendly way.

- " Ever since the argument, she's given me the cold shoulder.
- " He gave his old friends the cold shoulder after his promotion.

Steal someone's thunder — *take their credit*

To take the attention or credit that someone else deserves.

- " She announced her own news at his party and stole his thunder.
- " I didn't want to steal your thunder, so I stayed quiet.

Break the ice — *ease the tension*

To do or say something to make people feel more relaxed in a new or awkward situation.

- " A quick joke helped break the ice at the meeting.
- " We played a game to break the ice on the first day.

The ball is in your court — *your move now*

It is now your turn to make a decision or take action.

- " I've made my offer — now the ball is in your court.
- " She's replied to everyone, so the ball is in your court.

Sit on the fence — *stay neutral*

To avoid making a decision or taking sides in an argument.

- " Stop sitting on the fence and tell us what you think.
- " Politicians often sit on the fence to avoid losing votes.